

Campaign Strategy Guide

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PART 1: Why develop a campaign strategy?

Introduction

Detailed planning before you begin a campaign means that you know what your **objectives** are, **respond** effectively to new information and challenges without getting off track, send your key **audiences** clear and accurate **messages**, and **evaluate** once you're done. One of the most important ways a campaign strategy can assist you is by enabling you to define and differentiate your **vision**, **goals** and **tactics**.

Vision

Your vision is **what you are trying to ultimately achieve**. An example would be ANU committing to divest from fossil fuels. Your vision should always be **broad** and **inspirational**, so dream large on this one!

Goals

Your goals are the **steps along the way to achieving your vision**. Examples include your council agreeing to calculate the fossil fuel exposure of its investments or achieving majority support from staff and students in favour of your university divesting from fossil fuels. Your goals should all lead towards your vision, but they should be **specific** and **measurable**.

Tactics

Tactics are **the means to achieving your goals**. They are smaller steps that feed into the achievement of your goals and ultimately your vision. Examples include: organising a petition, staging a media action, or encouraging alumni to make future donations to their university contingent on fossil fuel divestment.

The strategy staircase

To differentiate between your **vision**, **goals**, and **tactics**, imagine your strategy as a staircase. The vision is at the top, goals are the individual steps, and tactics are how you reach each step.

PART 2: Campaign Strategy Development Tools

1. Visioning
2. SMART Goals
3. Determining what's achievable
4. Power mapping
5. Tactic development
6. Evaluation

2.1 Visioning

Before all else, give yourself the time to **clearly define your overall vision**. This will ensure that your goal-setting and tactic development flows smoothly. When fleshing out your campaign vision, ask yourself how you plan to:

- Effect **beneficial change** in people's lives
- **Empower** participants
- Alter **power relations**

Use these questions to **develop a concise vision statement**.

2.2 SMART Goals

Having established your vision, you can set goals to achieve it.

Your goals should always be **SMART** – that is **specific, measurable, achievable, realistic** and **time-specific**.

Specific

Make sure you construct boundaries around your goals, for example: ‘collect 5000 signatures for our divestment petition’ rather than ‘gain support for our campaign’.

Measurable

Your goals should be measurable so you know if you’ve achieved them, for example: ‘a signed commitment to divest from fossil fuels within 5 years.’ It’s important for everyone to know what constitutes a success.

Achievable

Set goals that are achievable, for example: ‘3 universities commit to fossil fuel divestment in 3 months’ rather than ‘all universities in Australia divest within 1 year.’ What’s achievable will depend upon your operating context.

Realistic

As distinct from achievable goals, determining what a realistic goal looks like requires an analysis of your campaign context. Being realistic doesn’t mean that you can’t be ambitious, it simply means that you should account for all of the obstacles that could impede your progress. For example, if your local council is highly unlikely to commit to divest, choose an easier institution with whom to partner first.

Time-specific

Giving yourself a time-bound goal, for example ‘two prominent institutions in our city divest within the first 6 months of our campaign’, gives you something to work

towards and a chance to pause, reassess how your strategy is progressing, and celebrate successes. You should set both long-term and intermediate goals.

2.3 Determining what's achievable

When developing a vision and goals, it's important to **set targets that can actually be achieved**. Sometimes this can be challenging as you may be faced with strong opposition or lack key resources. The key is to be pragmatic, develop **specific, measurable** targets and goals whilst **not compromising your ultimate vision**.

In determining what you are able to achieve, it can be helpful to examine both the **internal** and **external** constraints and opportunities governing your objectives.

Internal considerations refer to the factors within your group or organization that could influence your goals. These are more dynamic than external factors as you can more easily control them. When examining these factors it helps to ask:

- How many people are in your group/organization?
- What skills do they have?
- How much time can they commit?
- What resources (e.g. money, equipment, contacts) do you have access to?

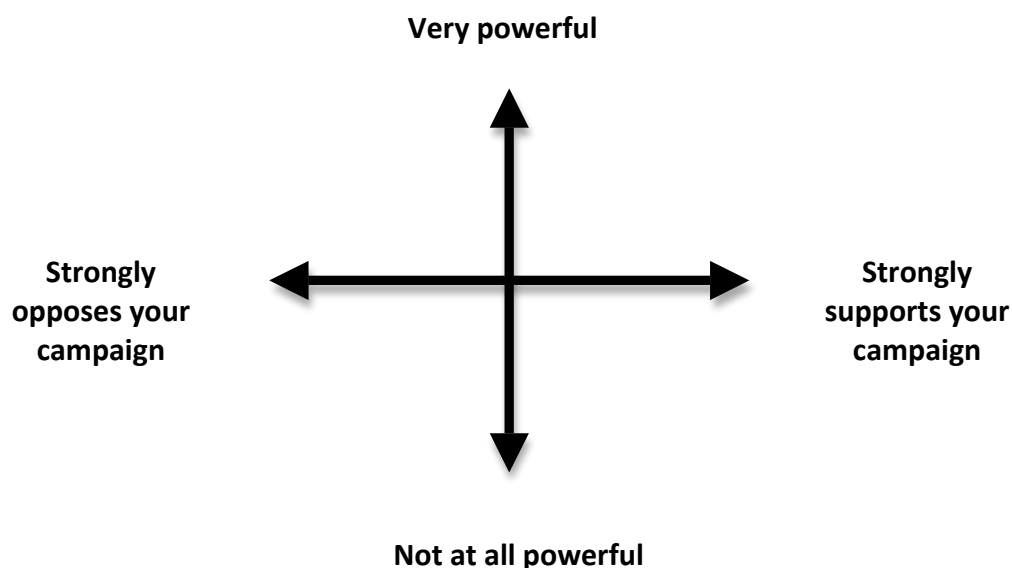
Unlike internal factors, **external factors** are less easily controlled. When examining these factors it can help to ask:

- Who are your supporters?
- Who are your detractors?
- What resources do your detractors have available to them?
- Why would others want to oppose you?
- What organizations/individuals can you partner with?
- What technology do you have access to?
- What is the political and economic climate in which you are working and is it conducive to your goals?

2.4 Power mapping

Determining what's achievable can be harder than it seems. Sometimes it helps to create a power map – in which you identify your **targets**, **constituents**, **allies** and **opponents**. In forming this map, list everyone who will be affected or involved in the campaign you are planning. The more **specific** you can be, the **stronger** your campaign plan and, most importantly, the more easily you can respond to roadblocks.

Once you've listed your actors, assign them to a position on your power map...



Looking at your map, you should be able to assign each actor to one of the following categories:

Targets – people you need to get on board or whose opinions you need to change for your campaign to be successful. Targets should be individuals, for example Minister X, business owner Y, rather than broad groups, for example business owners, residents, teachers. Within this group, you will have:

Primary targets – people you feel you can influence and who have the power to determine whether you achieve your goal. This isn't necessarily the person with the most power. Locating primary targets is a balance between identifying who gets to make the decisions and who you are most able to influence.

Secondary targets – people who can influence your primary target(s). Sometimes it is the friends and family of leaders who are most pivotal in their decisions, sometimes it is a board or committee. Ask yourself: who has power over the people with power to give you what you want? What influence do you have over these people?

Constituents – people you are representing, for example members, customers, staff, students, employees and anyone else who might benefit from the success of your campaign, including those who don't know it yet!

Allies – individuals, groups or organisations who will actively support you or whose goals are aligned with yours, for example your volunteers, like-minded opinion leaders, organizations, companies and celebrities. Work with your allies to strengthen your campaign.

Opponents – those who will or are likely to block your campaign, for example fossil fuel companies, adversarial politicians, and intractable fund managers. Consider how much power they wield, what your success would mean for them and what their strengths and weaknesses are. Under no circumstances should your opponents be your targets. Actively working to change people who are vehemently opposed to your campaign is a recipe for failure.

2.5 Tactics

This is the fun part where you get to plan specific actions to achieve your goals.

Well-planned tactics enable us to **leap** from one goal on the strategy staircase to the next. Whilst it is tempting to start campaign strategy planning by listing tactics you are interested in, it is important to **first set goals, create a power map and identify your resources**. This will ensure that your tactics support your **broader strategy for change**.

To be most effective, tactics should be:

- **Context appropriate:** for example, if your aim is to get extensive media coverage then plan your action or event in a way that minimizes barriers to media access, for example a media-friendly time and central location.
- **Flexible and creative:** plan for inclusivity and adaptability; creativity is a great way to convey a message and is much more effective than a serious, laboured approach. For example, when planning an action, including appealing visuals to attract attention.
- **Directed at a specific target:** ensure that the target is well-known and respected by your allies and constituents. Ensure that your messaging conveys this.
- **Understood and supported by your membership**
- **Backed by some form of power:** this should be a form of power that is highly respected by your constituents and targets. For example, if holding a rally, invite reputable opinion leaders to speak.

Your tactics should also **strengthen your group/organisation and build your members/support**. For example, if organizing a divestment forum, use the event as an opportunity to engage new volunteers and supporters.

When a tactic is part of a broader and well-organized plan, it has the potential to be very powerful. For example as part of a **vision** for all councils to become fossil free and a **goal** for all councils to measure and report on the carbon exposure of their investments, a carefully worded and planned petition with a specific ask, could be a very effective **tactic**.

Some **examples** of tactics include:

- Petitions, open letters and letters to the editor from key stakeholders
- Sit-ins and occupations
- Forums and debates
- Educational events (e.g. trainings and workshops)
- Flash-mobs

Remember, tactics can be as **creative** and whacky as you like, so long as they fit into a broader and well-planned campaign strategy.

2.6 Evaluation

At the end of a campaign, resist the temptation to jump onto the next campaign without reflecting on the one just past. Give yourself time to evaluate the strengths and weaknesses of your campaign as this will help you to improve and strengthen future work.

Consider the following :

- Did we establish mechanisms to measure our achievements?
- Did we achieve our goals?
- Are we closer to achieving our overall vision?
- What tactics were effective/ineffective?
- Did we use our resources well?
- Did we lack resources?
- Did we strengthen or weaken our group/organization through the campaign?

- Did we adequately account for and take advantage of the power dynamics at play?
- What were our overall strengths/weaknesses?

Jot your answers to these questions down and refer to them when planning future campaigns.

2.7 Summary of Tools

In conclusion, the process detailed above is summarized as follows:

1. Begin by defining your vision
2. Set SMART goals that feed your vision
3. Identify what is achievable
4. Map out the power relations and actors at play
5. Develop tactics that feed your goals
6. Evaluate your strengths and weaknesses and refer to these in future campaigns

PART 3: Further Campaign Strategy Resources

Many of the tips and tools in this document have been drawn from the following excellent resources:

- <<http://www.midwestacademy.com/>>
(in particular, [The Midwest Academy Strategy Chart](#))
- <<http://neworganizing.com>>
- <<http://www.thechangeagency.org/>>